

The Arkansas River

Location From Colorado to Arkansas, southern U.S.

The second longest tributary of the Mississippi–Missouri system, the Arkansas River rises in the Rocky Mountains, and its headwaters descend 4,600 ft (1,400 m) in 120 miles (193 km) through many systems of rapids. As it flows out of the mountains and is joined by numerous tributaries, the river widens significantly before joining the Mississippi near Napoleon, Arkansas, 1,469 miles (2,364 km) from its source. Water extraction has greatly reduced the flow of the river, but it is still an important waterway for barge transportation in eastern Oklahoma and Arkansas.

The Red River of the South

Location From Colorado and Texas to Louisiana, southern U.S.

Apart from being one of North America’s longest rivers, this river’s main distinction is that

the Prairie Dog Town Fork, one of the two major forks that form its headwaters, flows through the Palo Duro Canyon in northern Texas—the US’s second largest canyon after the Grand Canyon. Half of the river’s total length of 1,360 miles (2,190 km) forms the border between Texas and Oklahoma. The river once flowed into the Mississippi River but now joins the Atchafalaya River. Most of the river’s traffic is concentrated in Louisiana.

Mammoth Cave

Location The Appalachians of central Kentucky, eastern U.S.

The world’s longest known cave network, Mammoth Cave consists of 405 miles (652 km) of tunnels, shafts, and underground caverns in limestone that is more than 320 million years old. A resistant cap of sandstone covers the limestone. But where water has eroded through this, sinkholes have formed and water has flowed underground, dissolving the limestone and creating stalactites, stalagmites, and a spectacular accumulation of

calcium carbonate that has been named the Frozen Niagara because it looks like a waterfall.

The Great Dismal Swamp

Location Virginia and North Carolina, eastern U.S.

Despite its discouraging name, the Great Dismal Swamp is a beautiful complex of wetland habitats. This poorly drained area of forest, with Lake Drummond at its center, is one of the US’s largest swamps, with an area of more than 170 square miles (450 square km). Groundwater moves into the swamp from higher ground to the west but is held close to the surface by impermeable clay beneath. In winter and spring, the water table rises and the swamp floods, then in summer evaporation dries much of it out. Biodiversity is rich, with bald and Atlantic white cypress, maple, tupelo, and many other tree species, a diverse bird and reptile fauna, and populations of black bears and bobcats.

▼ THE HEADWATERS OF THE ARKANSAS RIVER

Ox Bel Ha

Location Quintana Roo state, southern Mexico

Meaning “three paths of water” in Mayan, this is the longest known undersea cave network in the world, comprising 170 miles (270 km) of tunnels close to and beneath the east coast of the Yucatan Peninsula. Created as water dissolved limestone, the caves later flooded as the sea level rose. They were inundated both by saltwater from the Caribbean Sea and fresh groundwater. The lighter freshwater flows on top of the heavier, near-static saltwater layer. The caves are accessed through several sinkholes.

Sistema Huautla

Location Oaxaca state, southern Mexico

The ancient limestone highlands of the Sierra Mazateca mountains contain one of the world’s finest collections of caves. First discovered in 1965, Sistema Huautla has subsequently been

